

90% COMPLETE[< Previous Lesson](#)[Next Quiz >](#)

12.1 Types of Possible Employment for F-1 Students

Focus Questions:

- *Who is not eligible for practical training?*
- *Who can offer CPT (Curricular Practical Training) work to international students?*
- *What forms are required for CPT work to be authorised?*
- *How many months of OPT could an international student in a STEM field be eligible for?*

On-Campus Employment

International students on F-1 status can work on campus 20 hours a week while school is in session, and full-time during scheduled breaks, such as winter and summer breaks. This work can occur on the school's campus or at an off-campus location "educationally affiliated with the school." In the latter case, the work must be "associated with the school's established curriculum or related to contractually funded research projects at the post-graduate level."

Here are some more details about on-campus employment for F-1 students according to **US Immigration and Customs**.

- It can be "work that takes place at the student's school location (such as at an on-campus commercial business, like a bookstore or cafeteria, as long as the work directly provides services for students)"
- It can be work with an employer that is contractually affiliated with the school is on-campus employment even if the work site is not located

- on the campus (such as a research lab affiliated with your school)
- An F-1 student may begin working as much as 30 days before the start of a program of study. They should inform the DSO before they begin work. They do not have to wait a full year before being eligible to work on campus.

Off-Campus Employment

There are not many opportunities for F-1 students to work off campus. The government notes,

“U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) will authorize off-campus employment only in cases of severe economic hardship occurring after a student’s enrollment in an academic program and after the student has been in F-1 status for at least one full academic year, or in emergent circumstances as defined by the Department of Homeland Security (DHS).”

However, there is an opportunity for some F-1 students to work with an international organization. *These students will have* been offered employment under the sponsorship of an international organization, as defined by the International Organization Immunities Act. For more information check [this government website](#).

Practical Training

Practical training is available to F-1 students who have been attending a college, university, or conservatory full-time for at least one academic year (in other words, nine months). High-school and English-language program students are not eligible for practical training even if the program is part of a college or university.

F-1 students can participate in employment directly related to field of study by obtaining practical training authorization. There are two types of practical training: Curricular Practical Training (CPT) and Optional Practical Training program (OPT).

Curricular Practical Training (CPT)

During their degree program, students can participate in Curricular Practical Training (CPT), which is training that must relate to their field of study – it must be an integral part of their curriculum and major. Students need the

approval of their Designated School Official (DSO) for CPT. (The DSO is the SEVP-certified school employee whose job it is to assist and oversee enrolled F and M students).

The work can be “alternate work/study, internship, cooperative education, or any other type of required internship or practicum which is offered by sponsoring employers through cooperative agreements with the school.” CPT can be part time or full time.

Authorization is for only one employer and for a specific period of time.

Employment of 20 hours per week or less is considered part time. Anything over 20 hours a week is considered full time. For the most part, only part-time CPT is permitted for undergraduate students while they are studying unless the CPT is part of an internship component of their program. Full-time CPT is generally permitted only when school is not in session.

Students are not limited in the amount of curricular practical training they may use. However, students who have engaged in one year or more of full-time curricular practical training are *not eligible* for Optional Practical Training. Students should ensure they track the hours they spend in CPT for this reason.

PLEASE NOTE: CPT requirements differ for undergraduate students and graduate students. Students should check with their International Student Office to be clear on all the details of CPT opportunities.

Internationalstudent.com says this about CPT:

“CPT is an opportunity for international students to earn extra money in US dollars, and to simultaneously get work experience in their field of study. Having international work experience immediately after graduation is immeasurably valuable when searching for a job and will allow you to establish global connections and references with professionals in your industry.”

There are two types of CPT: required and optional. If the CPT is required, it means the practical work training is mandatory for graduation. If it is optional CPT, the work experience is not required for graduation.

Internationalstudent.com notes that there are restrictions to think about for students considering CPT:

- “You must have been enrolled in school full-time for one year on valid **F1 status** (except for graduate students where the program requires immediate CPT)
- The CPT employment must be an integral part of your degree program or requirement for a course for which you receive academic credit
- You must have received a job offer that qualifies before you submit your CPT authorization request
- Your job offer must be in your major or field of study.”

For more information about CPT, please consult this **US Immigration and Customs Department website**.

Optional Practical Training

During or after their degree program, F-1 students can participate in the Optional Practical Training program (OPT) for up to 12 months (with an extension of 24 months available to STEM graduates and a 12-month extension possible for all F-1 students who progress to a higher level of study). To participate in OPT students need a recommendation from the DSO and approval by US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS). Their OPT program must relate to their field of study.

OPT is an opportunity for F-1 students to gain work experience to complement their academic program; as such, the work must be directly related to the student’s major area of study.

All F-1 students are entitled to one year of Optional Practical Training for each higher education degree they receive. The US government explains, “You can apply for 12 months of OPT at each education level, (i.e., you may have 12 months of OPT at the bachelor’s level and another 12 months of OPT at the master’s level).”

Students must have completed one academic year of their degree to be eligible for OPT.

Students who complete a degree on the STEM Designated Degree Program List may be entitled to a 24-month extension of OPT (36 months total). STEM refers to degrees in science, technology, engineering, or mathematics and includes:

- Actuarial Science

- Computer Science (except data entry/microcomputer applications)
- Engineering
- Engineering Technologies
- Biological and Biomedical Sciences
- Mathematics and Statistics
- Military Technologies
- Physical Sciences
- Science Technologies
- Medical Scientist

To qualify for the 24-month extension the students' employer *must* be enrolled in the E-Verify Employment Verification Program operated by US Citizenship and Immigration Services.

OPT for F-1 students can occur under four circumstances:

1. During the student's annual vacation and at other times when school is not in session if the student is eligible, and intends to register for the next term or session;
2. While school is in session provided that the OPT does not exceed 20 hours a week;
3. Full time after the student has completed all course requirements for the degree (excluding thesis or the equivalent), if the student is in a bachelor's, master's or doctoral degree program;
4. Full time after the student has completed a program of study.

The first three circumstances are referred to as "pre-completion" OPT while the fourth circumstance is called "post-completion" OPT.

To engage in OPT employment the student must apply for an Employment Authorization Document (EAD) from the DHS Service Center that has jurisdiction over the area where they live. The student's DSO would enable this via a recommendation.

OPT employment must be related to the student's field of study. A student studying communications, for example, is not eligible to work as a computer programmer on OPT. The student may not accept OPT employment until the DHS approves the application and provides the student with an EAD. This can take 90 days or more during the summer months.

[< Previous Lesson](#)

[Back to Lesson](#)

[Next Quiz >](#)